

26 — 7DAY — JOINT MOBILITY



The 7-Day Joint Mobility Protocol

A Gentle, Honest Guide to Moving Freely Again — and Feeling Like Yourself

by Emma

Because real relief comes from understanding your body — not pushing through it.

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1. Welcome — How to Use This Guide

Hi, I'm Emma. I'm so glad you're here.

If you picked up this guide, I'm going to take a guess about your mornings. You wake up, and before you've even opened your eyes all the way, your body sends you the bill for being alive another day. The knees that don't want to bend. The lower back that locks up. The hands that feel like they've been clenched into fists all night. **A lot of the people I talk to describe it the same way: "I feel like I got hit by a truck every morning."** Or they call their joints "rusty hinges." If that sounds familiar, you're in the right place, and I want you to know — I'm not going to talk down to you.

Let me be honest with you up front, because I think you've earned honesty. **I'm not a doctor, and this guide is not medical advice.** It's general information from one person who has spent a long time learning what actually helps and what's just noise. I'll say it again later because it matters: please check with your own doctor before you start anything in here, especially if you have a diagnosed condition, you've had a joint replaced, or you're managing other health issues. They know your body. I don't. This guide is meant to work *alongside* the people who care for you, never instead of them.

Here's what I'm NOT going to do. I'm not going to promise you a miracle. I'm not going to tell you that seven days will undo years of wear and tear, or that you'll be running marathons by Friday. **Anyone who promises you that is either lying or selling something.** What I *can* tell you is this: gentle, consistent movement is one of the most respected, doctor-recommended things you can do for stiff, aching joints — and most people never do it, because nobody ever showed them how to start small and safe.

So that's what this is. A simple, gentle, **seven-day on-ramp** back to moving with a little more ease.

Here's how to use it:

- **Read one chapter a day, in order.** Don't rush ahead. Each day builds on the last and gives your body time to adjust.

- **Every movement in here is gentle on purpose.** We're talking about mobility, light stretching, and range of motion — never anything intense, never anything that puts you at risk. If something hurts in a sharp or wrong way, you stop. Soreness is not the goal. *Ease* is the goal.
- **Go at your pace.** If a movement is too much today, do a smaller version. There's no gold star for pushing through pain in this house.
- **Pair it with whatever already helps you.** I'll be honest about what I personally reach for when my own joints are giving me grief — a deep-penetrating balm I use, called Kalmely — but I want to be clear from the start: **the method matters more than the product.** The movement is the heart of this. The balm is just a tool that makes the movement more comfortable.

You don't need to be flexible. You don't need fancy equipment. You just need to show up for yourself for seven days. **You've carried this body through a whole life. Let's spend a week being a little kinder to it.**

Let's begin.

2. What's Really Happening in an Aching Joint

I want to start here, because nobody ever sat me down and explained it plainly. They hand you a word like "arthritis," maybe a leaflet, and send you on your way. So let me talk to you the way I wish someone had talked to me.

A joint is simply the place where two bones meet. Your knee, your hip, your knuckle. And where they meet, the ends of the bones are capped with something called cartilage. Think of it as a smooth, slippery cushion. When everything is working, that cushion lets the bones glide past each other quietly and easily. You don't even notice it. You just move.

Over the years, that cushion can wear thinner. This is ordinary. It happens to most of us who live long enough, and it is not a sign that you did anything wrong or "let yourself go." It's the mileage of a life well lived. But as the cushion thins, the bones start to sit closer

together. When it gets very thin, you may have heard a doctor use that phrase that lands like a stone in your stomach: **"bone on bone."**

Here's what that actually feels like, and why. With less cushion, the smooth glide turns into more of a grind. Your body notices the rubbing and responds the only way it knows how: with **inflammation**. Inflammation is just your body's repair crew showing up. The trouble is, the crew brings swelling, heat, and stiffness along with it. So the very thing meant to protect you is part of what makes the joint feel hot, puffy, and sore.

That's why it hurts more when you move. Standing up from a chair, climbing the stairs, reaching for a top shelf, getting down on the floor with the grandkids, these all load the joint and press those tender surfaces together. The pain is real. It is not in your head, and you are not being dramatic.

And then there's the mornings. So many people tell me the same thing: **"I feel like I've been hit by a truck before I've even had my coffee."** Rusty hinges. Here's the simple reason. When you rest for hours, fluid settles and the inflammation has time to thicken and stiffen, like jelly setting overnight. The joint hasn't moved, so it's gone gummy and tight. Those first steps out of bed are you working the stiffness loose. It usually eases a little once you get going, which is your first clue that **gentle, regular movement is a friend, not an enemy.**

This is also why a menthol cream can feel like a letdown. It cools the skin on top, which is pleasant, but it wears off in twenty minutes because it never reached the part that actually aches. The discomfort isn't on the surface. It's deeper, in the joint itself.

I'm telling you all this not to frighten you, but to put you back in the driver's seat. **When you understand what's happening, you stop fighting your body and start working with it.** That's the whole spirit of this little protocol.

A gentle note: this is general information, not medical advice. Please check with your own doctor before starting anything new, especially if you have a diagnosed condition.

3. Your Trouble Spots: Knees, Back, Shoulders & Hands

Joint pain doesn't show up the same way for everyone, and it doesn't pick the same spot. So let's walk through the four places I hear about most. You may recognize yourself in one of these, or, if you're like a lot of us, in all of them at once. Knowing how each one behaves makes it far less frightening and far easier to care for.

Knees. These are the workhorses, and they pay the price. Your knees carry your whole weight every time you stand, sit, or take a step, so they're often the first to complain. People describe a deep ache, a grinding or clicking, and that awful moment of hesitation at the top of the stairs. Going *down* is usually worse than going up, because that's when the joint takes the load. **The knee that aches most is often the one you trust least,** and that loss of trust is its own kind of pain. It's why so many tell me the real heartbreak isn't the stairs, it's not getting down on the floor with the grandkids.

Back. The back is a long stack of small joints, and stiffness here is incredibly common. It tends to show up as a low, dull ache that's worst first thing in the morning or after you've been sitting too long. Bending to tie your shoes, lifting the laundry basket, twisting to back the car out, these are the everyday moments that catch you. Your back loves gentle motion and dislikes staying frozen in one position, which is exactly why long stretches in a chair leave you stiff as a board.

Shoulders. Shoulders are the most mobile joint in the body, so when they stiffen, you feel the loss sharply. The tell-tale signs are reaching, the top shelf, fastening a bra, putting on a coat, washing your hair. Many people also get woken at night because they rolled onto that side. That nighttime ache that pulls you out of sleep, **what I call "painomnia,"** is one of the most exhausting parts of all this, because poor sleep makes everything else hurt more the next day.

Hands. The hands are where it gets personal, because they're how we *do* things. Opening a jar, turning a key, doing up buttons, holding a pen, gripping a knitting needle. The knuckles can feel swollen and stiff, and the fingers may not bend as freely as they did. There's a particular grief in this one, because your hands are tied to your independence and to the things that make you *you*.

And that's the thread running through all four: **this was never really about joints. It's about staying who you are.** Moving freely, doing for yourself, being in the thick of family life.

When I tend to a stubborn spot, **my go-to is a deep-penetrating balm, Kalmely, with arnica, boswellia, and MSM**, because it works its way down toward the joint instead of just cooling the skin and quitting after twenty minutes. But I'll say this plainly: the brand matters less than the habit. The gentle movement, the daily care, the showing up for yourself, that's the real medicine.

A reminder: a topical balm can help soothe and support sore joints, but it isn't a cure, and none of this replaces your doctor's guidance. Please check in with them, especially before starting new movement.

4. Why the Pain Keeps Coming Back

Let me guess. You've had a good day. Maybe two. You moved a little easier, you slept through the night, and you let yourself think, *Maybe this is finally turning a corner.* And then you woke up and felt like you'd been **hit by a truck** all over again.

I want you to know something right away: **that's not you failing. That's not you doing something wrong.** That's the nature of the thing you're dealing with. And once you understand why it keeps coming back, you stop blaming yourself, and you start working with your body instead of fighting it.

Here's the honest picture.

Most of the joint pain we deal with as we get older doesn't live on the *surface*. It lives **deep inside the joint** itself, where the cartilage has worn thin and the area gets inflamed and irritated. That deep irritation is the real source of the ache, the stiffness, the **rusty hinges** feeling when you first stand up. It's down in the joint, not on the skin above it.

So picture a weed in your garden.

You can go out and mow the top off it. For a day or two, the lawn looks fine. Smooth. Tidy. But you and I both know that weed is coming back, because **the root is still down there**, untouched. You didn't remove it. You just trimmed what you could see.

That's exactly what happens with most pain relief. A lot of what we reach for only ever touches the top of the weed. It quiets the surface for a little while, the discomfort fades, and we feel hopeful. But the inflammation deep in the joint, the actual root, is still sitting there doing its thing. So the pain comes back. Not because you did anything wrong, but because **the root was never reached**.

This is why two things matter so much, and why I keep coming back to them in this little book.

First, gentle daily movement. When you move a joint slowly and safely through its range, you help keep it nourished and a little less stiff. We'll do those movements together in the coming days, and they're soft on purpose. No straining, no "push through it." Just kind, steady motion.

Second, getting relief down to where the trouble actually is. This is where surface solutions tend to let us down, and it's why I lean on a **deep-penetrating balm** rather than something that only sits on top of the skin. My go-to is **Kalmely**, with arnica, boswellia, and MSM, because it's made to sink down toward the joint instead of stopping at the surface. But please hear me: **the principle matters more than the brand**. What matters is reaching the root, not just mowing the weed.

When you stop expecting surface fixes to solve a deep problem, the whole picture gets less discouraging. You're not broken. You were just trimming the top.

Tomorrow, we go for the root.

5. Why Pills and Ordinary Creams Let You Down

If you've ever stood in front of the medicine cabinet, bottle in one hand, tube in the other, thinking *neither of these really works for long*, I want you to know you're not imagining it. **You're right**. And you deserve an honest explanation of why, not a sales pitch.

Let's start with the pills, the **ibuprofen and the other anti-inflammatories**.

I'm not here to tell you they're useless. They're not. On a bad day, they can take the edge off, and there are times that's exactly what a person needs. I'd never look down on anyone for reaching for them.

But here's the part the box doesn't say loudly enough: **these aren't built for everyday, long-term use**. Taken day after day, month after month, they can be hard on the stomach and rough on the kidneys, and that risk tends to grow as we get older. So many people I've spoken to are quietly **afraid of what the pills are doing to their stomach**, and that fear is reasonable. You shouldn't have to trade your gut for your knees. Nobody should be made to feel they have only those two choices.

(And this is the right moment to say it plainly: **I'm not your doctor, and this isn't medical advice**. If you're taking anything daily, please talk it over with your own doctor before you change a thing. That conversation is worth having.)

Now, the creams. The **menthol ones**, the ones that go on cool and tingly.

You've felt it. That rush of cold, that minty bite, and for about **twenty minutes it feels like something's happening**. Then it fades, and the ache walks right back in like it never left.

Here's why. Most of those creams work by creating a cooling sensation **on the surface of your skin**. That's the whole trick. The cold feeling distracts you from the pain for a little while, the way running cold water over a sore hand feels nice in the moment. But that menthol never travels down to the joint. **It cools the skin and then it wears off**. The trouble underneath was never reached, so of course the relief doesn't last.

So that's the real reason both of them let you down. The pills can carry a cost when you lean on them daily, and the surface creams **never get deep enough to matter**.

This is the whole reason I went looking for something different, and why I keep coming back to a **deep-penetrating balm** like Kalmely, with arnica, boswellia, and MSM. It's designed to actually sink toward the joint, not just throw a cold sensation across the skin and quit. I won't promise you a miracle, and I'd be wary of anyone who does. **It doesn't**

"cure" anything. What it can do is help support and soothe the joint, working closer to where the ache really lives.

You're not too picky. You were just handed tools that stop at the surface. Let's go deeper.

6. How a Deep-Penetrating Balm Reaches the Ache

Let me tell you about the moment I stopped trusting most creams.

For years, I'd rub something on my knee, feel that cool tingle, and think, "There, that's working." And for about twenty minutes, it did. Then the cool faded, the ache came right back, and I was reaching for the tube again. I bet you know that feeling. **That tingle isn't the pain leaving. It's just a distraction sitting on top of your skin.**

So here's what I learned, and it changed how I think about all of this.

Most drugstore creams are built around menthol or camphor. They create a hot-or-cold sensation on the *surface* of your skin. It feels like something is happening, and your brain is busy noticing the cool or the warmth instead of the deep ache underneath. That's a real effect, and on a hard day, I'll take any relief I can get. But it's a costume. It doesn't travel to where the ache actually lives, **down in the joint and the muscle around it**, and that's why it wears off so fast.

A deep-penetrating balm is built to do the opposite. Instead of staying on the surface, it's designed to **carry its active ingredients down through the skin toward the tissue underneath**, closer to the source of the discomfort. The goal isn't to fool your nerves for twenty minutes. The goal is to reach the place that's actually bothering you.

What makes the difference is what's *in* it, and how those things move.

Arnica has been used for generations for sore, overworked, bumped-and-bruised tissue. It's one of those quiet old-fashioned remedies your grandmother might have known about.

Boswellia, which you may have heard called frankincense, is a botanical that people have leaned on for stiff, achy joints for a very long time.

MSM is a form of sulfur that the body uses naturally, and it's often included because it's thought to support the comfort of joints and muscles.

The point of a good balm is to deliver those carry-deep ingredients to the tissue, rather than letting them sit and evaporate on top.

Now, I have to be honest with you, the way I'd want a friend to be honest with me. **A balm like this is not a cure.** It does not rebuild a worn joint, and it won't undo years of wear. Nothing rubbed on the skin can promise that, and anyone who tells you otherwise isn't being straight with you. What a good balm *can* do is help, soothe, and support, so the morning feels a little less like rusty hinges and the floor with the grandkids feels a little more possible.

The one I reach for is **Kalmely**, because it combines arnica, boswellia, and MSM in exactly this carry-deep way, and it doesn't quit on me at the twenty-minute mark. But please hear this: **the method matters more than the brand.** What matters is that you choose something that goes *toward* the ache instead of sitting on top of it.

And as always, if you have a health condition or take medication, run any new product past your doctor first. You deserve relief that's honest, and care that's safe.

7. The 7-Day Joint Mobility Protocol — Day by Day

Here's the part I'm most proud of. Everything you've read up to now has been the *why*. This is the *what to do*.

I built this protocol for one reason: most "joint programs" are written for thirty-year-olds at the gym. They tell you to do lunges and planks, and frankly, that's not what you and I need. **We don't need to get stronger overnight. We need to move a little more freely each day, gently, without paying for it the next morning.**

So this is seven days of *easing the rust out of the hinges* — one area of the body at a time. Each day takes about ten to fifteen minutes. No floor crawling, no equipment, nothing that leaves you sore.

A few ground rules before we start, and please don't skip them:

- **Gentle always wins.** You should feel a mild stretch, never a sharp pain. If something hurts, *stop*. Pain is a stop sign, not a goal.
- **Slow is the whole point.** Move like you're moving through water. Rushing is how people get hurt.
- **Breathe.** Don't hold your breath. A relaxed muscle moves better than a clenched one.
- **Check with your doctor first**, especially if you've had a joint replaced, a recent fall, or any condition that affects your balance or bones. This is general information from me, Emma — not medical advice, and not a cure for anything.

A quick word on the balm, since people ask. **My go-to is Kalmely, but the method matters more than the brand.** What matters is using a deep-penetrating balm *before* you move, so the area is warm and looser when you start, and *at night*, so you're not woken at 2 a.m. by that deep ache. Wherever I say "apply your balm," that's why.

Alright. Let's begin.

Day 1 — Knees

The knees carry you everywhere, so we start here.

1. Seated knee extensions. Sit tall in a sturdy chair, feet flat. Slowly straighten one leg out in front of you until it's roughly level, hold for two seconds, then lower it just as slowly. Do 8 on each leg. No kicking — *slow and smooth*.

2. Heel slides. Still seated, slide one heel back along the floor toward the chair, bending the knee as far as is comfortable, then slide it forward again. 8 each side. This gently restores your range of motion.

3. Gentle marching. Seated, lift one knee an inch or two, set it down, then the other. Like a slow, lazy march. 10 total.

Balm: Apply to both knees *in the morning before you begin*, and again *at night* before bed.

Tip of the day: Warmth is your friend. A warm shower or a few minutes with a heating pad before you move makes everything easier. Cold, stiff joints don't want to cooperate — give them a head start.

Day 2 — Lower Back

If your back feels like it's been "hit by a truck" every morning, today's for you. All of this is done lying down or seated, very gently.

1. Knee-to-chest, one at a time. Lie on your back on a bed or mat. Slowly draw one knee up toward your chest, hands behind the thigh (not on the kneecap), hold for three breaths, lower it. 5 each side. *Never force it.*

2. Gentle pelvic tilts. Lying on your back, knees bent, feet flat. Slowly flatten your lower back into the surface by tilting your pelvis, hold two seconds, release. 8 slow repetitions. This is a tiny movement — it should feel soothing, not strenuous.

3. Seated side reach. Sit tall, reach one arm gently up and slightly over to the opposite side until you feel a light stretch along your ribs and lower back. Hold three breaths, switch. 3 each side.

Balm: Apply to your lower back *the night before* and again *first thing in the morning* — the back tends to seize overnight, so morning application makes a real difference.

Tip of the day: Stop slouching into soft chairs. A small rolled towel behind your lower back while you sit supports the natural curve and takes pressure off all day long. Little things add up.

Day 3 — Shoulders

Stiff shoulders make reaching the top shelf — or fastening a seatbelt — a daily battle. We'll loosen them kindly.

- 1. Shoulder rolls.** Sit or stand tall. Slowly roll both shoulders up, back, and down in a big lazy circle. 8 backward, then 8 forward. Smooth, not jerky.
- 2. Wall walks.** Stand an arm's length from a wall. Walk your fingers slowly up the wall as high as is *comfortable*, hold a moment, walk them back down. 5 times. Don't push into pain — let it improve a little each day.
- 3. Gentle hug stretch.** Wrap your arms around yourself as if giving yourself a hug, feel the light stretch across your upper back. Hold three breaths. Repeat 3 times.

Balm: Apply to the shoulders and upper back *before you start* these movements, so they're warm and willing.

Tip of the day: Notice where you carry tension. Most of us creep our shoulders up toward our ears without realizing. A few times today, just let them drop. That small release, done often, is its own gentle therapy.

Day 4 — Hands & Wrists

We don't talk about hands enough. But stiff, achy fingers make buttons, jars, and holding a grandchild's hand harder than they should be.

- 1. Slow fist and spread.** Hold your hands out, gently close them into a soft fist, then open and spread the fingers wide. 10 slow repetitions. Easy does it — no squeezing hard.
- 2. Wrist circles.** Hold your arms out, let your hands relax, and slowly circle the wrists 8 times one way, 8 the other.
- 3. Thumb touches.** Touch your thumb to each fingertip in turn, slowly and deliberately, like counting on your fingers. Do two full rounds on each hand. Wonderful for dexterity.

Balm: Apply *in the morning*, massaging it gently into the knuckles and the base of the thumb where the ache tends to settle. The massaging itself helps.

Tip of the day: Warm water works wonders for hands. Soak them in a basin of warm water for a few minutes, or do these exercises right after washing the dishes when they're already warm and loose.

Day 5 — Hips & Balance

Hips and steadiness on your feet — this is the day that helps you feel *secure* when you walk. **Do every standing exercise next to a counter or sturdy chair you can hold.** Safety first, always.

1. Standing hip circles. Holding the counter, slowly trace a small circle with one knee/hip, like stirring a pot with your leg. 5 each direction, each side. Small and slow.

2. Side leg lifts. Holding on, lift one leg gently out to the side a few inches, lower it. 8 each side. You're not trying to lift it high — just to wake the hip up.

3. Supported standing balance. Stand tall, lightly resting fingertips on the counter, and try to put a little less weight on your hands. Just stand steady for 10–15 seconds. *Keep a firm grip ready.* This rebuilds confidence on your feet.

Balm: Apply to the hips *the night before*, so any deep ache that wakes you is calmer.

Tip of the day: Good footwear at home matters more than people think. Flat, supportive, non-slip — not floppy slippers. Steady feet make for steady hips.

Day 6 — Full-Body Gentle Flow

Today we tie it all together with a slow, flowing sequence. Think of it as a *gentle good-morning to every joint*. Move through it once, unhurried.

1. Slow neck turns. Seated, turn your head slowly to look over one shoulder, back to center, then the other. 4 each way. Easy — the neck is delicate.

2. Seated cat-cow. Sit tall, hands on knees. Slowly round your back and drop your chin (like a slow exhale), then gently arch and lift your chest. 6 slow rounds. This is lovely for the whole spine.

3. Ankle pumps and circles. Seated, point and flex each foot 8 times, then circle each ankle 5 times. Keeps the lower joints supple.

4. A gentle full-body shake-out. Stand (holding support), and softly let your arms swing and your knees give a tiny bounce, loosening everything. 20 seconds.

Balm: Apply to *whichever area has bothered you most this week*, before your flow. You know your body's troublemaker by now.

Tip of the day: Notice how much easier today feels than Day 1. That's not luck — that's your joints responding to consistent, kind movement. Write down the one thing that's improved. Progress you can see keeps you going.

Day 7 — Rest & Restore

This is not a day off. **It's a day of active recovery** — and it's just as important as the rest.

1. Easy walking. A short, flat, comfortable walk — even just around the house or garden — at your own pace. Five to ten minutes. Movement, not exercise.

2. Long, slow breathing. Sit comfortably. Breathe in for a count of four, out for a count of six, and let your whole body soften. 10 breaths. Tension lives in the joints too, and this lets it go.

3. Gentle full-body stretch. Reach your arms slowly overhead (or as far as comfortable), have a good long stretch like you're waking from a nap, then relax. 3 times.

Balm: Apply *at night*, taking a moment to massage it in slowly. Make it a small ritual — the end of a week you should be proud of.

Tip of the day: Be kind to yourself today. You showed up seven days running, and that's more than most people do. *Consistency, not intensity, is what brings movement back.*

After Day 7 — Begin Again

Here's the truth nobody tells you: **this isn't a one-week fix. It's the start of a gentle habit.** Joints don't respond to a single hard push — they respond to small, kind, repeated movement over time.

So after Day 7, go right back to Day 1 and run it again. Each week it gets a little easier. The movements that felt tight in week one start to feel ordinary. That stiffness you'd made peace with begins to quietly loosen its grip.

You don't have to do it perfectly. You just have to keep showing up — gently, patiently, with the balm warming the way and a little more freedom waiting on the other side.

Movement is yours to reclaim, one easy day at a time.

And remember: if anything ever hurts, stop, and when in doubt, ask your doctor. Moving freely again is the goal — staying safe is how we get there.

8. How to Get Better Results, Faster

Let me be honest with you about something, because I think you deserve honesty more than hype.

There is no magic switch. Anyone who tells you they can erase years of stiff, aching joints overnight is either selling you a fantasy or hasn't lived in a body like yours or mine. **What I can offer you instead is something better: a handful of small, sensible habits that remove the obstacles in your way, so the work you're already doing actually has a chance to land.**

That's the real secret. We're not adding magic. We're clearing the path.

Warm up before you do anything. Cold, stiff joints are like a door hinge that hasn't been opened in years. If you force it, it creaks and protests. So give it a little warmth first. A warm shower, a heating pad for a few minutes, even just cupping your hands around a

warm mug and then over the joint. Warmth invites the tissue to soften and the blood to move. Everything that follows works better on a warm joint than a cold one.

This is also the best moment to apply your balm. Skin that's warm and clean, right after a shower, simply takes things in more readily. My go-to is Kalmely, with its arnica, boswellia, and MSM, because I want something that travels down into the joint rather than sitting on top and fading in twenty minutes. But honestly, the timing matters as much as the brand. Warm skin, then apply, then let it absorb before you dress.

Be consistent. Morning and night. I know that's the boring advice. But your joints don't respond to heroics. They respond to repetition. A little support first thing, when you feel rusty, and a little before bed, when the night aches tend to creep in, does more than one big effort on Sunday and nothing the rest of the week. Think of it like watering a plant. Small and steady wins.

Keep moving, gently, every single day. I'll say more about this in the next chapter, but movement is the thing that feeds a joint. Even a slow walk to the kitchen and back, a few gentle ankle circles, opening and closing your hands. Motion is lotion, as an old physio once told me. Don't push into sharp pain, ever. Just keep the hinges oiled with kind, easy movement.

And don't forget the unglamorous basics. Drink your water, the tissue around your joints is mostly fluid and it gets cranky when you're dry. Protect your sleep, because that's when your body does its quiet repair work. These feel too simple to matter. They matter enormously.

A quick, important word: this is general information, not medical advice. Please check with your doctor before starting anything new, especially if you have a condition or take other medicines.

None of this is dramatic. That's rather the point. You stack the small things, you give it a few weeks, and one morning you notice you reached for something without bracing. That's how this works.

9. Mistakes That Keep You Stiff

I want to start this chapter by lifting something off your shoulders.

If you've been stuck, it wasn't your fault. Most of the mistakes I'm about to describe are things sensible, careful people do precisely because they're trying to protect themselves. You weren't being foolish. You were being cautious in a way that, unfortunately, backfired. Now that you know better, you can do better. That's all this is.

Here are the ones I see most often.

Resting it completely. This is the big one, and it's so understandable. It hurts, so you stop using it. You sit more, you move less, you "save" the joint. But a joint that doesn't move gets stiffer, not safer. The surrounding muscles weaken, the joint dries out, and the whole thing seizes up further. Gentle, daily movement, within a comfortable range, is medicine. Stillness, past a point, is the trap.

Only treating it when it flares. When the pain spikes, you spring into action, balm, heat, the lot. Then the flare passes and you forget all about it until the next one. But this is reactive, and reactive is always a step behind. The steady, quiet, twice-a-day care, even on the good days, is what keeps the bad days further apart. Treat the calm, not just the storm.

Expecting it overnight. We've all been trained by adverts to want instant results. So we try something for three days, feel "not much," and give up, when we were closer than we thought. Joints heal and respond on their own slow clock, often over several weeks. Give your routine a fair, patient run before you judge it. Quitting early is the most common reason good methods get blamed for not working.

Stacking everything at once. When the pain is loud, the temptation is to throw pills and creams and gadgets at it all together, hoping something sticks. Please be careful here. Mixing medicines, especially anti-inflammatory tablets, with other things isn't always safe, and it can be hard on your stomach. **This is exactly the kind of decision to bring to your doctor or pharmacist rather than sorting out alone.** And just so

we're clear, a topical balm like Kalmely is meant to soothe and support the area, not to cure arthritis or replace anything your doctor has prescribed.

Pushing through sharp pain. I admire grit. But there's a difference between the dull ache of a joint waking up, which you can gently work with, and a sharp, stabbing, "stop right now" pain, which is your body sounding an alarm. Honor that alarm. Ease off, rest that movement, and if sharp pain keeps happening, get it checked. Toughing it out here doesn't make you stronger. It just makes you more likely to be sidelined.

Notice the thread running through all of these: they're errors of either doing too much in a panic or too little out of fear. The sweet spot is the boring middle, gentle, steady, patient, consistent.

You're not starting over. You're just steering around the potholes now. And that small shift in how you approach this can change everything.

10. Protecting Your Joints, Day to Day

Here's something I wish someone had told me sooner: the work you do in those seven days matters, but so does everything you do in the other twenty-three hours and fifty minutes of your day.

You don't have to wrap yourself in cotton wool. You're not fragile. But there are small, ordinary habits that either protect your joints or quietly wear them down, and most of us were never taught the difference. So let me share what I've learned, gently.

Move often, sit less. I know that sounds backward when everything aches. But joints are a bit like rusty hinges, and a hinge that never moves seizes up. The fluid that keeps your joints comfortable only circulates when you move. So the goal isn't one big effort, it's frequent, easy motion. **If you've been sitting for thirty minutes, get up, walk to the kitchen, roll your shoulders, and sit back down.** That's it. Stillness is the thing that makes the next time you stand up feel like you were hit by a truck.

How you get up and down is half the battle. When you rise from a chair, scoot to the edge first, plant both feet, lean your nose over your toes, and push up with your legs, not your back. Use the armrests. There's no medal for doing it the hard way. When you lower yourself, reach back for the seat first and ease down with control instead of dropping. Your knees will thank you.

Mind your feet. This one surprises people. Soft, supportive shoes with a bit of cushion change how every step lands all the way up to your hips. Worn-out slippers and bare floors send the shock straight into sore joints. **A good pair of cushioned shoes is honestly one of the kindest things you can do for your knees.**

Let warmth be your friend. Heat relaxes stiff tissue and helps you move more freely, which is why mornings, when you're coldest, are often the worst. A warm shower, a heat pad, or a few minutes warming up before you ask your body to do anything can make a real difference.

This is also where my warm balm earns its place in the day, not just during the protocol. **My go-to is Kalmely**, with arnica, boswellia, and MSM, and what I appreciate is that it penetrates deeply toward the joint rather than tingling on the surface and wearing off in twenty minutes like the menthol creams. I'll work a little into a knee or shoulder before a walk. But honestly, the habit of caring for the joint matters more than any one brand.

A few simple things at home. Raise the seat you use most so you're not sinking too low. Keep the things you reach for between hip and shoulder height, so there's less bending and stretching. Carry less, more often, instead of one heavy trip. And spread the load across both hands or a bag on your shoulder rather than dragging it all with one sore wrist.

None of this is dramatic. That's the point. **You protect your joints in small, dignified moments, all day long.** And as always, if something feels wrong or sharp, stop and check with your doctor, especially if you have a condition. This is general guidance from one person to another, not medical advice.

11. Keeping the Movement You've Won Back

If you've reached this part of the book and you're moving a little more freely than you were a week ago, I want you to pause and notice that. **You earned this.** Not a pill, not luck. You showed up for yourself, gently and consistently, and your body responded.

Now let's talk about keeping it, because that's the part nobody prepares you for.

Here's the honest truth, told plainly: **movement you don't use, you slowly lose.** Joints respond to what you ask of them. Ask for a little easy motion regularly, and they tend to stay looser and more comfortable. Go quiet for two weeks, and the stiffness creeps back in like an old houseguest who lets himself in the door. This isn't said to frighten you. It's said so you don't blame yourself if you ever slip. You just begin again.

You don't need to do the full seven-day push forever. That was the reset. Maintenance is lighter. For most people, running through the gentle mobility and range-of-motion movements **two or three times a week** is enough to hold onto what you've gained. Think of it less as exercise and more as keeping the hinges oiled. Twenty quiet minutes, a few times a week. That's the whole ask.

Pick your anchor. The people who stick with it are the ones who attach the movements to something they already do. After your morning tea. Before the evening news. The day doesn't need a special slot, it needs a familiar one. **Consistency, not intensity, is what keeps you moving like yourself.**

Listen to your body, and respect what it tells you. Some days you'll feel loose and capable. Other days you'll feel like rusty hinges again, and that's allowed. On the harder days, do less, do it slower, but try to do something, because a little gentle motion on a stiff day is often exactly what eases it. The rule I live by is simple: **gentle discomfort that fades is fine, sharp pain is a signal to stop.** If pain is new, severe, or won't settle, that's a conversation for your doctor, not something to push through.

This is where the balm becomes part of your routine rather than a rescue. I keep mine by the bed and by the kettle. **A little Kalmely worked into a stiff knee or shoulder before my movements helps me move more comfortably,** and on the nights

when an aching joint used to wake me, that bit of care before bed has spared me a good deal of that two-in-the-morning misery. It supports the joint and soothes the ache. It doesn't cure anything, and I'd never tell you otherwise, but comfort that helps you keep moving is worth a great deal.

So here's where I leave you. The goal was never just less pain. It was getting back down on the floor with the grandkids, sleeping through the night, feeling like yourself again. **Keep the movement, gently and faithfully, and it tends to keep you.** You've already proven you can do this. Now it's simply a matter of staying, kindly and patiently, on your own side.

12. Staying Strong Enough to Care for the People Who Need You

There's a kind of pain nobody warns you about, and it isn't in your knees or your back. It's the pain of looking at someone you love — a husband, a wife, a sister, a parent who is older than you — and knowing they're counting on you, while your own body is quietly falling apart.

I hear from people in this exact spot more than you'd think. **You're the caregiver.** You're the one who helps your spouse out of the chair, who drives to the appointments, who carries the groceries and keeps the house running. And you do it with a body that wakes up feeling like it was hit by a truck.

So let me say something you may not have heard in a long time: **you matter too.**

I know how that sounds. I know that when someone needs you, taking care of yourself feels selfish, or like one more thing on a list that's already too long. But here is the plain truth, and I'm telling it to you because I respect you too much to dress it up. **You cannot pour from an empty cup.** If your knee gives out lifting your husband, now there are two people on the floor. If your back seizes up and you can't drive, the appointments don't happen. Caring for yourself isn't taking something away from the person you love. It's protecting them.

I want you to think of your own body as part of the equipment you depend on — like your car or your reading glasses. You wouldn't skip the oil change and then act surprised when you're stranded. **Your joints deserve the same basic maintenance**, and the gentle protocol in this book takes only a few minutes a day. You can do most of it sitting down, in the same chair where you keep your loved one company.

Here's something I've watched happen, and it always moves me. When you start moving a little easier — when getting up doesn't make you wince, when the night pain settles down so you actually sleep — you become *more* of the person you've always been. Steadier. More patient. More yourself. The people who depend on you feel that. **Your calm is contagious, and so is your strain.**

On the days the soreness is loud, a little extra help is fair game. I keep my balm within reach for exactly these moments — mine is Kalmely, worked into the knees or low back before a long day of lifting and bending. It's a deep-penetrating balm, not one of those menthol creams that go cold and then quit on you twenty minutes later. It helps take the edge off so I can keep doing what needs doing. **But the method matters more than the brand** — the daily movement is what holds it together.

And please, hear this. **Ask for help. Let people help you.** You're allowed. The strongest thing a caregiver ever does is admit they need a hand too. You've spent your life showing up for others. There is real dignity in showing up for yourself — not instead of them, but *so that you can keep showing up* for them, for a good long while yet.

13. When to See a Doctor

I've spent this whole book talking about gentle movement and what you can do at home, and I believe in every word of it. But I'd be doing you a disservice if I didn't draw a clear line, plain as day, about when home care isn't enough — and when it's time to pick up the phone and call your doctor.

So let me be straight with you, the way I'd want someone to be with my own mother.

Most joint aches are the slow, grinding, familiar kind. They come on over months and years. They're worse in the morning and ease as you move. That's the kind this book is built for. But some pain is a different animal, and it's asking for a professional set of eyes.

Please call your doctor — and don't sit on it — if any of these show up:

- **Sudden, severe pain** that hits out of nowhere, especially if you can't put weight on the joint or can't move it at all.
- **A joint that's swollen, red, hot to the touch, or visibly out of shape.** Warmth and redness can signal infection or inflammation that needs treating, not stretching.
- **Pain that follows a fall, a twist, or a hard knock.** At our age, what feels like "just a bad bruise" can be a fracture. Get it looked at.
- **Pain with a fever, chills, or feeling unwell all over.** That combination is your body waving a flag.
- **Numbness, tingling, or weakness** running down an arm or leg, or trouble with your balance.
- **Pain that simply isn't improving** — or is steadily getting worse — after a few weeks of gentle care. Not getting better is information. Listen to it.

There's one more thing, and I say it because I care. **If you live with diabetes, poor circulation, a condition affecting your immune system, or you're on blood thinners, your bar for calling is lower.** A small swollen spot or a sore that won't heal deserves attention sooner rather than later, because these conditions change how your body signals trouble. When in doubt, ask. That's what your doctor is there for.

I want to be careful not to scare you. **The vast majority of the aches and stiffness we've talked about are not emergencies** — they're the ordinary wear of a body that's carried you faithfully for decades. But you know yourself better than anyone. If something feels *off* — different from your usual, sharper, wrong — trust that instinct. You've earned the right to be taken seriously.

And one honest reminder: everything in this book, including anything I say about my balm, is **general information, not medical advice**. It's not a substitute for your own doctor, who knows your history and can examine you. Before you start a new routine — especially if you have a health condition — have a quick word with them. A two-minute conversation can give you the confidence to move forward without second-guessing yourself.

Asking for help isn't weakness. It's wisdom. Make the call.

14. Myths, Facts & Your Questions Answered

Over the years I've heard the same handful of beliefs repeated so often that people take them as gospel. The trouble is, some of them are flat-out wrong, and a few of them are quietly keeping good people stuck. So let me clear the air, gently and honestly.

Myth: "It's just old age. Nothing helps, so why bother?" This is the one that breaks my heart, because it talks people into giving up before they've even tried. Yes, joints change as we age — that part's true. But "nothing helps" is simply not so. **Gentle, regular movement is one of the best-studied things you can do for stiff joints.** It nourishes the joint, keeps it limber, and supports the muscles around it. Age is not a sentence to sit still. It's a reason to move *smarter*.

Myth: "Rest is best. If it hurts, stop moving." This one feels right, which is why it fools so many people. But for everyday stiffness, **too much rest often makes joints stiffer and weaker, not better.** Joints are a bit like rusty hinges — they loosen with use, within reason. The trick is *gentle* movement, not punishing it. We're not training for a marathon. We're keeping the door swinging freely. (Sharp, sudden, or swollen pain is the exception — see the last chapter.)

Myth: "All the creams are the same." Not even close. Plenty of drugstore rubs are mostly menthol — they create a cold or hot sensation that distracts you for a little while, then wear off in twenty minutes and leave you right where you started. What I look for is something that actually **penetrates deeper, toward the joint itself**, rather than just sitting on the surface. My go-to is Kalmely, a deep-penetrating balm with arnica,

boswellia, and MSM. It helps soothe and support the achy spot rather than masking it briefly. **But honestly — the brand matters less than the principle.** Surface tingle and real relief are two different things.

Myth: "If it gets bad, you just have to live on pills." Pain pills have their place, and I'd never tell you to ignore your doctor's plan. But a lot of folks are frightened of leaning on NSAIDs day after day, worried about their stomach — and that fear is understandable. The good news is that **daily movement and topical relief can do real work alongside, or sometimes instead of, reaching for the bottle every morning.** Talk it through with your doctor. You may have more options than you think.

A few quick questions I get all the time:

How long until I feel a difference? Be patient. Gentle movement often shows up over a few weeks, not days. A topical balm can take the edge off much sooner, but the lasting change comes from consistency.

Can I use the balm daily? I do, on my knees and low back, morning and evening. Follow the label, keep it off broken skin, and check with your doctor if you have a condition.

Will it work for me? I can't promise that — no one honest can. Bodies differ. But **gentle movement helps the vast majority of people who stick with it**, and a good balm is a low-risk way to support it. Give it a fair, steady trial. You're worth the effort.

A Closing Note from Emma

You made it.

Seven days. I hope you feel a quiet little bit of pride about that, because you should. **Showing up for yourself every day — even when your body was sore, even when you didn't feel like it — that's not a small thing. That's character.** And it's the same character that got you this far in life.

I won't pretend this week erased years of wear and tear. It didn't, and I'd never insult you by saying so. But here's what I hope you noticed, even in small ways: a knee that bent a

little easier on day six than day one. A morning where getting out of bed didn't feel quite so much like negotiating with a stranger. A reach into the top cupboard that didn't make you wince. **Those small wins are real, and they add up — but only if you keep going.**

So let me leave you with three things, the same three I tell everyone I care about.

Be patient. Joints don't change on our schedule. They change on theirs. The progress you want is measured in weeks and months, not days. If you only got a little this week, that's not failure — that's the beginning. Keep the door open.

Be consistent. This is the big one. A little bit of gentle movement most days will always beat a heroic effort once a month. You don't need to do all of it, all the time. You just need to keep coming back. Pick the two or three movements that felt best to you and make them yours. Tie them to something you already do — your morning coffee, the news, a phone call with the grandkids.

Be gentle. With your body, and with yourself. There will be hard days — days when the weather turns and everything aches, days when you wake up feeling like those rusty hinges again. On those days, do the smaller version. Or just do the breathing. Or just rest.

Resting on a bad day is not quitting. It's wisdom. You and I both know the difference by now.

And please, keep your doctor in the loop. Tell them what you're doing. Let them cheer you on and keep you safe. The goal was never just to hurt less. The goal was to keep doing the things that make you *you* — getting down on the floor with the grandkids, walking out to the garden, standing at the stove making the meal everybody loves. **To feel like yourself again.** That's the whole point. The rest is just details.

I'm proud of you. Truly. Go be gentle with yourself today.

With warmth, **Emma**

A small reminder: everything in this guide is general information, not medical advice. Please talk with your doctor before continuing, especially if you have a health condition. The balm I mentioned, Kalmely, is meant to soothe and support comfortable movement — it's a helping hand, not a cure.